

Social structure of Indus Valley Civilization

S.K.Venkatesan
CQRL Bits, Chennai

We briefly study the social strata of Indus Valley Civilization (IVC) as obtained from the insight offered by Dravidian decipherment of the author [1] and as well through the various material artifacts unearthed [2, 3].

Seal from Bactria Afghanistan



Source: Vidale [2]

Text: ᄃᆞ: ᄃᆞᆫᄃᆞᆫ: ūril-uvan-ullavan

Semantics: The town's food provider, the all-powerful rich man.

This is a commentary on inequality by an IVC person on Bactria, Afghanistan.

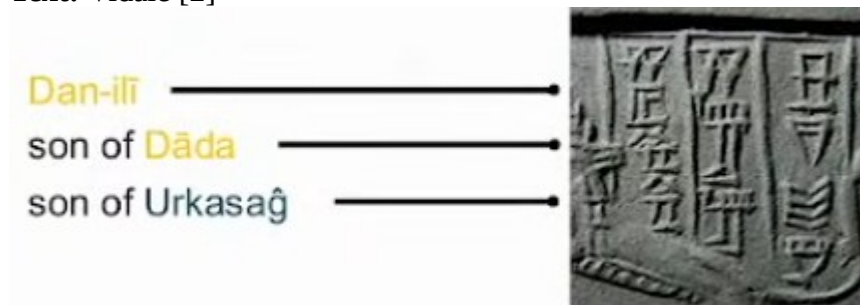
Sumeria vs Meluko (Indus) skirmish



Source: Boehmer [3]

Semantics: This is an encounter between Indus and Sumeria (in the bordering forest region), Indus being depicted by the bull (muri, marru: barter trader denoted by bull, meluko – region of raised forts) and Sumeria by the Lion (urumu, Lion king).

Text: Vidale [2]



From Indus decipherment [1]:

𐎶𐎶 – an-an – annan¹ – leader – 𐎶𐎶 – ūran – town-head – ūr-sag (Sumerian)

Indus internal skirmish and resolution



¹ In modern Tamil the word “annan” denotes elder brother, but I am informed by knowledgeable sources that the modern family with male-dominant elder-brother probably did not exist in the IVC society. This was surprising for myself, but the decipherment seem to indicate existence of such a different kind of social system. Even now in Tamilnadu “anan”/“anata” is used to address every male in a brotherly fashion (a bit like how communists address “comrade”). This is a bit sex-neutral in structure also, although the chieftains tend to be male most of the time. The suffix “-an” means “human” and not a gender suffix as is now used in Modern Tamil. Genderfication of Dravidian languages happened many millennia later after the rise of kingdoms. Pilot-Raichoor [4] has done pioneering research in this area.

Text: 𒊕𒌷𒍪 𒍪𒌷, taḷu-utai

Semantics: Push-kick (skirmish)



Text: 𒌷 𒌷𒍪𒌷𒍪, cēru-kotṭu-tam-ar

Semantics: Fighting among themselves



Text: 𒌷𒍪𒍪 𒍪𒌷𒍪, kuru-vilaku-ar-kanni-anuppu

Semantics: Send for dispute solver



Semantics: Reports the atrocities in bull province on women/people.

Analogy: Picasso's Guernica:



A photograph of two men playing mridangam drums. They are shirtless, wearing white dhotis and yellow headbands. They are standing in front of a large, colorful mural of a face, likely a deity. The man on the left is playing a mridangam with a stick, while the man on the right is playing a mridangam with a stick.

Barter and marriage between provinces

